

tween the organised job market and rural or less-educated youth seeking livelihood options. In order to achieve this, the company started a vocational training centre in Aurangabad in association with Pratham last year. The course offers intensive six-month training in various aspects of hotel operations to youngsters hailing from the nearby villages. Apart from this, Taj also has partnered with several

recruitment manager at Tata Trent: "We recruit about 1,500 people each year for our stores and for this we are now working with NGOs and vocational training institutes which can deliver trained and ready-to-employ manpower."

In order to plug these loopholes, NGOs and companies are working at imparting skills to the weaker sections of society, both in rural and

vate vocational training institutes, which charge the Government for providing this training.

One of the biggest gaps these courses plug is the ability to converse in English. The Smile Twin e-Learning Programme (STEP) of Smile Foundation offers a six-month course which has been designed with industry inputs and is customised according to trade needs. The International Management Institute (IMI), Delhi, has developed a majority of the curriculum. Likewise, the computer education programme is based on the Microsoft Unlimited Potential Programme. Explains Naresh Chaudhary, CEO of Smile Foundation:

PRIYANKA GOSAVI, 21 Mumbai Process Executive

Discovered Deutsche Bank's training centre, run in collaboration with Pratham. Learnt spoken English, basic banking and accounting. Now works with an MNC bank.



"I had done many courses but this one prepared me for the job market. Now I want to complete M.Com."

Vedanta Foundation

Through the Vedanta Shiksha, the foundation reaches out to local groups and offers basic courses in computers, office applications, desk top publishing and financial accounting. Also gives a certificate.

Number of centres: 200

Present in: 14 states



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government-run vocational training institutes to train youth from weaker sections of the society.

Clearly, children who do not have access to quality higher education need to be taught skills that can help them become part of the organised workforce. Like any other big metro, Mumbai too has scores of graduates coming out of Marathi medium schools and colleges, but they are not employable as their education has not prepared them for the realities of the job market. Explains Nikhil Dalvi,

urban India. Hyderabad-based CAP Foundation's Ek Mouka Jobs provides training in entry-level technical skills, life skills and spoken English to youth between 18 and 30 years. All the vocational training programmes are market-linked and are classified into verticals like fashion, healthcare, ITES, retail and automobile. These centres seek to link education to livelihoods. With the Central Government setting aside Rs 15,000 crore for the NSC mission, this also makes good business sense for pri-

"It's difficult for people from the economically weaker sections of society to find jobs even if they have studied till high school but most of them nurture ambitions of white collar jobs. Our course prepares them for multiple industries like BPO, healthcare and retail."

While the stories of Kotkar, Shishir Kumar and Priyanka Gosavi are inspiring, skilling India's rural youth will be work in progress till the country does not beat the cycle of poverty. ■